Rhetorical analysis: cram sheet

AP English Language · timed write Fri 11/6

Key ideas

1. **30 points**: thesis 6, development 10, prose 10, organization 4. Each error costs 4.
2. **Purpose** and **audience** beat strategies. Name an obvious and a subtle purpose, and use the **blurb**.
3. 40 minutes: 12 to read, plan and write the thesis, 28 to write. Aim for **450 words**.
4. Skip low-level strategies: rhetorical questions, imagery, plain ethos, pathos or logos. One sentence at most.
5. Cite the text in every body paragraph, inside your own sentences. Never "this quote."

Score

30 points

Thesis 6	clarity 2, complexity 4
Development 10	cited evidence; strategies, purpose, audience; the blurb; the connection
Prose 10	word choice, syntax, sentence variety, em dash, colon, semicolon
Organization 4	high-level transitions and a satisfying conclusion
Errors	minus 4 each
A range	12 to 14 of the 14 prose and organization points

Time

40 minutes

Plan 12	blurb, two reads, purpose, audience, strategies, thesis
Write 28	two body paragraphs and a conclusion, then proofread
Length	450 words now; 500 is the year goal
Passage	blind, likely a complete piece

Situation

complexity

Blurb	the 3 to 4 sentences before the passage; use it in the thesis and every body paragraph
Audience	adjectives: feelings, desires, background, beliefs and values
Exigence	what pushes the writer to speak now
Purpose	multifaceted: obvious plus subtle or long-range
Nuance	the connection between purpose, strategies and audience

Thesis

one sentence

Formula	situation, audience, "a multifaceted purpose:" both purposes, strategies
Rules	third person, no contractions, no figurative language, no wordiness
Names	title and full name first, last name after, never first name alone

Body paragraphs

by purpose

BP1, BP2	obvious purpose, then the subtle one
Open with	purpose, audience and the situation, not a strategy
Combine	strategies that work together share a paragraph
Evidence	cite in every body paragraph, inside your sentences; vary citations; never "this quote"
Shoes	say what this audience feels and wants

Strategies

must-use when found

Identity	patriotic appeal, religious appeal, biblical allusion, diction and dialect
Build	amplification, parallelism, tricolon, tetracolon, anadiplosis
Contrast	antithesis, juxtaposition, short sentence after long
Voice	point-of-view shift, tone shift, comic relief, satire
Moment	kairos, call to action, personal anecdote
Skip	rhetorical question, imagery, plain ethos, pathos, logos: one sentence at most

Prose

10 points

Long, short	a short, impactful sentence after a long one
Punctuation	semicolon joins two sentences; colon delivers the point; em dash for an aside
Variety	sentence length and starters

Model thesis: In his battlefield speech in the film Braveheart, Scottish rebel William Wallace addresses a frightened, untrained army of farmers with a multifaceted purpose: to rally them against the English that day and to make them see themselves as Scots united in a country of their own; through comic relief, amplification and patriotic appeals voiced in Scottish dialect, Wallace turns their fear into resolve. **BP** = body paragraph.